A Journey in Political Thought and Action

Nikhil Dey

The Bharat Jodo Yatra was a mammoth exercise in scale and ambition, but at its core was the simple idea of establishing direct communication with people. Had this communication been one-sided, it would have been largely an exercise in political propaganda. However, because of the way it was shaped and structured, it became a uniquely effective forum for re-establishing democratic consultation and dialogue. It demonstrated the power and potential of listening, and using it to contribute to progressive policies and change. The name ‘Bharat Jodo’ and some of its stated objectives would naturally measure its impact as a ‘campaign’. However, it was much more. The extensive interactions with people and civil society organizations need deeper analysis. The outcomes push us to look at how the Yatra also evolved into a live and moving platform for participatory and consultative policy formulation, and for democratic governance.

How the Yatra Directly Shaped Policy

While there were many policy initiatives that were strengthened by the discussions in the Yatra, one needs to be especially highlighted. The discussions around the increasingly vulnerable plight of workers in the emerging and growing gig economy in India and across the globe led to a significant breakthrough in establishing the social security rights of gig workers through state-level legislation. The gig workers’ social security legislation was built around the principles that were discussed, and evolved